



△ THE "BISHOP'S CHAIR"

This ornately carved 13th-century chair from the chancel, ornamented with animal heads, shows the Viking tale of Sigurd the Dragon-slayer reworked as a Christian allegory.

▽ MASTERWORK OF WOOD

Constructed around a timber framework, the church has stood for more than 800 years. Distinctive wooden shingles add to its striking appearance.

Heddal Stave Church

The largest of Norway's elaborately carved stave churches and a masterwork of medieval wooden construction



Rising nearly 82 ft (25 m) high, Heddal Stave Church is the largest remaining stave church in Norway. Around 1,500 of these huge structures—which are held up on strong wooden posts supporting heavy horizontal beams—were built in Norway in the Middle Ages, but only 28 survive to this day.

A history in timber

Archaeologists have been able to date the church by analyzing its timbers. The wood was harvested before 1196, and the church is thought to date from around the reign of King Sverre Sigurdsson (1177–1202), a period of extensive church building. Over the centuries, the church was altered, but in 1939, it was restored and returned close to its medieval state.

Heddal's four carved portals have been preserved; the details of animal motifs, foliage, and masks on them demonstrate the height of medieval craftsmanship. While some of the church's treasures have been moved into museums, the elaborate 17th-century altarpiece showing the Crucifixion is still used in the church.

FLOOR PLAN AND CONSTRUCTION

The sophistication of the exterior of the Church masks the simplicity of its floor plan, which follows the tradition of other Christian churches except that stone columns are replaced by load-bearing wooden posts, or staves, sunk into holes in the ground. Above the floor, a system of boxes and triangles supports the roof and the vertically fixed wall planks.

